As a result of geographical discoveries, the seventeenth century witnessed the emergence of various East India Companies such as the English East India Company, the Dutch East India Company, and the French East India Company.

The Portuguese, after discovering a new sea route to India, enforced its monopoly on the spice trade of East Indies, eliminating competition of the Arabs, Egyptians and Venetians by use of military force. The Spaniards established monopoly over the mining and transportation of gold and silver in its colonies in the New World.

The English East India Company had monopoly trade in India and amassed huge wealth. Thus, the chief feature of mercantilism was exploitation of the resources of the colonies for the benefit of the colonisers. It represented an important stage in the development of modern capitalism.

Recap

- The Renaissance, Reformation and Geographical Discoveries are heralds of the modern age.
- The new ideas of humanism, individualism, rationalism and nationalism provided the basis for the beginning of an era of enlightenment.
- Scientific development led to invention of new instruments and discovery of new sea routes to the east.
- There were revolutionary changes in political, economic and cultural spheres.

India at the dawn of Modern Age in Europe

The Mughal rule had started since 1526 A.D. (C.E.). Vijayanagar state, founded in 1336, was a great power under Krishnadeva Raya (1509-29 A.D. (C.E.)). Portuguese established their empire in the East (India, Malacca, Ceylon) and controlled the sea with Goa as headquarters. In Tamilnadu Madurai Nayak rule began dividing the Pandya kingdom into seventy two *palayams*. The arrival of Jesuit Missions and the work of St. Francis Xavier, as a member of Society of Jesus, led to conversion of fishing community to Christianity (Catholicism) in Thoothukudi region.



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